THE FUTURE OF WORK

Motivation when work itself is changing

Organizational Behaviour

AI

changes tasks. Design changes the experience.

Motivation → Job design

The labour market is changing faster than many jobs can adapt

Technology

AI, automation and digital access are changing which tasks people perform.

Skills

Employers expect 39% of workers' core skills to change by 2030.

Careers

Entry-level work is especially exposed because routine learning tasks are easier to automate.

The motivation question: what will people experience inside redesigned jobs?

OPENING CASE

A redesigned graduate role: better work—or a broken pathway?

A professional-services firm introduces an AI assistant.

- Routine research and first drafts are automated.
- Graduates receive complex client work earlier.
- Goals and feedback are generated from performance data.
- Promotion depends partly on metrics captured by the system.

DISCUSS

What might increase motivation?

What might reduce it?

Motivation explains where effort goes—and whether it lasts

Direction	Intensity	Persistence
Which goal or activity receives attention?	How much physical or cognitive effort is invested?	How long is effort sustained despite difficulty?

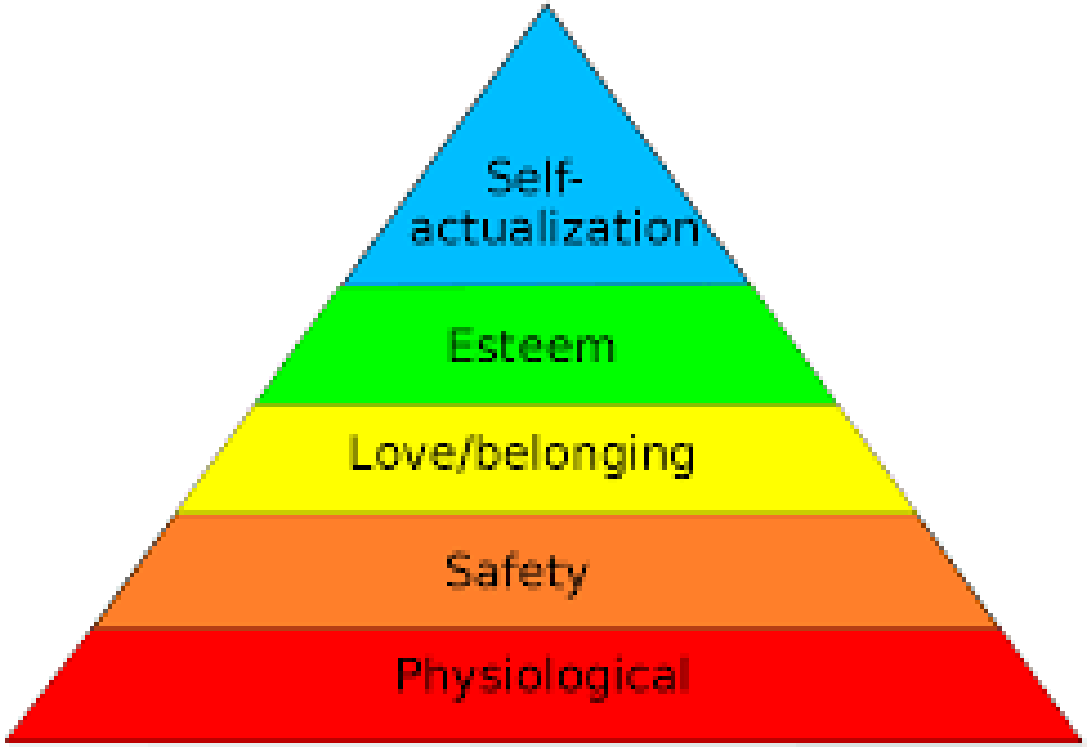
Performance also depends on ability, resources, role clarity and opportunity.

Six theories ask different—and complementary—questions

NEEDS	CHOICES & GOALS	FAIRNESS
Hierarchy of Needs Two-Factor Theory Self-Determination Theory	Goal-Setting Theory Expectancy Theory	Organizational Justice

No single theory explains motivation on its own.

Need theories ask what people seek from work- Maslow's Hierarchy



Future-of-work lens

When tasks change, which human needs are strengthened, and which are put at risk?

Maslow is a useful checklist—not a reliable staircase

The proposition

Needs range from physiological and safety needs to belonging, esteem and self-actualization.

What it highlights

Employees can value security, relationships, recognition and growth—not only pay.

Use with caution

Needs need not follow a fixed sequence. People pursue several needs at once; culture and circumstances matter.

Ask “Which needs matter here?”—not “Which level is this employee on?”

Two factor approach: Fixing dissatisfaction does not automatically create motivation

HYGIENE FACTORS

Pay
Policies
Supervision
Working conditions
Job security

MOTIVATORS

Achievement
Recognition
Meaningful work
Responsibility
Growth

Future-of-work question: does AI merely remove unpleasant tasks—or create richer work?

High-quality motivation rests on three psychological needs

AUTONOMY

I experience meaningful choice and ownership—not simply freedom from all constraints.

COMPETENCE

I can learn, master challenges and see evidence of progress.

RELATEDNESS

I feel respected, connected and significant to others.

Self-Determination Theory focuses on the quality—not just the quantity—of motivation.

The same technology can support or frustrate motivation

AI AS AUGMENTATION

More discretion
Faster feedback
Stretch assignments
Access to expertise
More time for relationships

AI AS CONTROL

Prescribed workflows
Continuous monitoring
Deskilling
Opaque evaluation
Isolation from colleagues

The motivational effect depends on implementation and job design—not the tool alone.

Maya joined Horizon Analytics eight months ago as a graduate data analyst. She earns a competitive salary, has good benefits and works in a comfortable office two days per week. The organization has a strong reputation, and her position appears secure.

When Maya started, she expected to work with experienced analysts and gradually take responsibility for client projects. Instead, a new AI system now completes much of the initial data preparation and analysis. Maya checks its output, corrects formatting and prepares standardized presentation slides.

Her manager believes the technology has improved Maya's job. It has removed repetitive technical work, reduced overtime and allowed her to work from home three days per week. Maya's performance reviews are positive, and she recently received a small pay increase.

However, Maya says she is becoming less motivated. She rarely sees a complete project and does not know how clients use her work. Because most communication occurs through task-management software, she has little contact with senior analysts or other graduates. Her manager assigns tasks through the system and checks her output but rarely discusses how she could develop.

Maya has asked to attend client meetings and take responsibility for a small project. Her manager responded that she should first demonstrate greater enthusiasm and consistency in her current tasks. Maya has begun doing only what is required and is quietly looking at other jobs.

- What diagnosis would **Maslow** produce?
- What diagnosis would **Two-Factor Theory** produce?
- What diagnosis would **Self-Determination Theory** produce?
- Is one diagnosis best?

Process theories ask how motivation becomes action

Need theories	Goals and expectations	Action
What do I seek?	What should I do, and will it work?	Direction • effort • persistence

Motivation depends on both the target and the path to a valued outcome.

Specific, challenging goals usually focus and sustain effort

Effective goals

Specific
Challenging
Relevant
Realistic
Timed
Supported by feedback

A note on SMART goals…

They influence

Attention
Effort
Persistence
Strategy development

They also require

Ability and resources
Task knowledge
Commitment
Learning time

For complex or unfamiliar work, learning goals may outperform narrow performance goals.

Goals can have side effects



BENEFITS

Clarity
Fast feedback
Visible progress
Coordination at scale

RISKS

Tunnel vision
Metric gaming
Unethical shortcuts
Neglect of unmeasured work

When a metric becomes a target, people may optimize the number rather than the purpose.

Ordonez et al., 2009

PAIR DISCUSSION

Apply goal-setting theory to the graduate role

The system gives every graduate this target:

> **“Increase client-ready output by 25% this quarter.”**

1 • Diagnose

What behaviour will this goal direct? What might it neglect?

2 • Redesign

Rewrite it as a learning goal for an employee new to AI-enabled work.

Expectancy Theory asks: “Is the effort worth it?”

EXPECTANCY

If I make the effort, can I perform?

Effort → Performance

INSTRUMENTALITY

Will performance produce the promised outcome?

Performance → Outcome

VALENCE

Do I value that outcome?

Outcome → Value

Motivation is weak if any one link is close to zero.

Rapid skill change can weaken every expectancy link

Can I succeed?

Training, time, usable technology, confidence and access to help.

Will it count?

Transparent criteria and a credible connection between learning, performance and advancement.

Is it worthwhile?

Rewards employees value: security, pay, flexibility, meaningful work or future opportunities.

“Be resilient” is not motivating when the organization withholds the means to adapt.

People judge not only outcomes, but how organizations reach them

DISTRIBUTIVE	PROCEDURAL	INTERPERSONAL + INFORMATIONAL
Are outcomes (pay, opportunities, workload) allocated fairly?	Are decisions consistent, unbiased, accurate and open to employee voice?	Are people treated with dignity and given honest, adequate explanations?

A decision can be disappointing yet still be experienced as fair.

AI-enabled management creates new questions of fairness

- Who receives augmentation and whose role is automated?
- How does AI affect the fairness of recruitment and performance review processes?
- Can managers understand and justify an algorithmic 'decision'?
- Are training and advancement opportunities distributed fairly?
- Who is accountable when the system is wrong?

Efficiency does not settle questions of legitimacy.

Northstar Energy recently introduced an AI-supported customer-service system. Management expected the system to reduce waiting times and improve consistency.

The 40 service advisers were given a new target: resolve 90% of customer cases during the first interaction while maintaining an average handling time below six minutes. A dashboard displays each adviser's results and ranks team members weekly. Managers receive bonuses when their teams meet both targets.

After three months, average handling time has fallen, but customer complaints and repeat calls have increased. Some advisers end difficult calls early and record them as resolved. Others transfer unusual cases to colleagues so that the cases do not affect their own scores.

Employees received a two-hour introduction to the new system. The AI sometimes recommends irrelevant or incorrect solutions, particularly for unusual billing problems. Experienced advisers know when to ignore it, but newer employees are less confident. They have asked for additional training, but management says that the system was designed to be intuitive.

Employees were originally told that strong dashboard results would influence promotion and access to flexible working. Two recently promoted advisers had only average scores, however. Management explained that it also considered "leadership potential," although employees do not know how this was assessed.

The team had not been consulted about the targets. When employees raised concerns, their manager said the targets came from head office and applied equally to everyone. Individual rankings remain visible, but employees cannot inspect the data used to calculate their scores or formally challenge errors.

Absence and turnover intentions have increased. Senior management believes employees are resisting accountability and is considering raising the first-contact-resolution target to 95%.

Diagnose using goal setting, expectancy theory, and organizational justice concepts
Is one best?

Need and work-experience theories: three different lenses

Hierarchy of Needs

Core question
Which needs might work satisfy?

Best contribution
Broadens attention beyond pay.

Main caution
No fixed universal hierarchy.

Two-Factor Theory

Core question
What prevents dissatisfaction, and what enriches work?

Best contribution
Highlights meaningful work.

Main caution
The two categories overlap.

Self-Determination

Core question
Does work support autonomy, competence and relatedness?

Best contribution
Explains motivation quality.

Main caution
Support depends on context.

Goals, expectations and justice explain different parts of action

Goal-Setting

Core question
What target directs effort?

Managerial lever
Clear, challenging goals and feedback.

Risk
Narrow targets distort behaviour.

Expectancy

Core question
Is there a credible route from effort to a valued outcome?

Managerial lever
Capability, reliable rewards and valued outcomes.

Risk
One broken link weakens motivation.

Justice

Core question
Is the employment relationship fair?

Managerial lever
Fair outcomes, processes, treatment and explanations.

Risk
Efficiency can conceal inequity.

THE BRIDGE TO JOB DESIGN

Technology changes tasks.

Job design determines what those changes mean for motivation.

AUTONOMY	LEARNING	MEANING
Who controls how work is done?	Where do competence and feedback come from?	Can employees see a whole and significant contribution?

Next: designing human–AI work

Job characteristics model: Jobs motivate through the experiences they create

SKILL VARIETY	TASK IDENTITY	TASK SIGNIFICANCE	AUTONOMY	FEEDBACK
Use different skills	Complete a whole piece	Affect other people	Control how work is done	Learn how well it went

Experienced meaningfulness

Experienced responsibility

Knowledge of results

Together, these psychological states support internal motivation, satisfaction and performance.

Job redesign changes the work

JOB ROTATION

Move periodically among tasks or roles.

Can increase variety and understanding.

Risk: several shallow tasks may remain unmotivating.

JOB ENRICHMENT

Increase control over planning, execution and evaluation.

Can strengthen autonomy, responsibility and feedback.

RELATIONAL REDESIGN

Connect employees with customers, beneficiaries or colleagues affected by their work.

Can increase task significance and meaning.

Future-of-work test: does automation remove drudgery or remove identity, learning and meaning?

Employees should help design the jobs they must inhabit

Employee involvement

A participative process that uses employees' input to increase commitment to organizational success.

INFORMATION	—	Employees understand the proposed change and the evidence behind it.
VOICE	—	Employees can identify task dependencies, risks and sources of meaning.
INFLUENCE	—	Input can alter decisions—not merely validate a predetermined design.
REVIEW	—	The redesigned job is monitored and revised using employee experience.

Involvement can improve design quality and strengthen autonomy, ownership and acceptance.

Rewards work best when they reinforce rather than substitute for good job design

INTRINSIC REWARDS

Come from the work experience itself:

Meaning • mastery • autonomy • progress • contribution

EXTRINSIC REWARDS

Come from the employment exchange:

Pay • bonuses • benefits • promotion • recognition

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Use fair, valued external rewards—while preserving discretion, learning and meaningful feedback.

Controlling rewards can crowd out intrinsic motivation.

Apply it: redesign one AI-enabled role using the five job characteristics, employee voice and a coherent reward system.

Job design shapes motivation before incentives are added.

Emotion ☺ ☹

Emotions are episodes; moods are background states

EMOTIONS

Relatively intense

Usually linked to a person, object or event

Often brief and action-oriented

MOODS

Usually less intense

May lack an obvious trigger

Often last longer and shape interpretation

COMMON SOURCES

Personality • sleep • stress
time of day • social interaction
exercise • work events • culture

Weather is often less influential than people assume.

In hybrid and digital work, emotions remain present—even when their cues are harder to read.

Emotional labour makes feelings part of the job

Felt emotion

What I actually feel

Displayed emotion

What the role expects me to show

Emotional dissonance

The gap between the two

SURFACE ACTING

Change the visible expression while the underlying feeling remains.

Often effortful and associated with strain.

DEEP ACTING

Try to change the underlying feeling to match the expected display.

May feel more authentic, but still requires effort.

Display rules can support service—but chronic dissonance can contribute to exhaustion and withdrawal.

Affective Events Theory: Small workplace events accumulate into attitudes and behaviour



Affective Events Theory

- Events trigger emotional reactions—not just rational evaluations.
- Personality and current mood shape the strength of the reaction.

Managers influence emotion through everyday events—not only major policies.

Ask what repeatedly happens during the working day—not only whether the job is "good."

Emotional intelligence



Rate 1=strongly disagree, 5= strongly agree

1. Appraisal of Own Emotions

I know why my emotions change.

I easily recognize my emotions as I experience them.

2. Appraisal of Others' Emotions

I can tell how people are feeling by listening to the tone of their voice.

By looking at their facial expressions, I recognize the emotions people are experiencing.

3. Regulation of Own Emotions

I seek out activities that make me happy.

I have control over my emotions.

4. Regulation of Others' Emotions

I arrange events others enjoy.

I help other people feel better when they are down.

5. Utilization of Emotions

When I am in a positive mood, I am able to come up with new ideas.

I use good moods to help myself keep trying in the face of obstacles.

Emotional intelligence supports better choices—not perfect control

PERCEIVE

Notice emotional cues in oneself and others.

UNDERSTAND

Interpret causes, patterns and likely consequences.

USE

Integrate emotion with attention, judgment and communication.

REGULATE

Influence emotion without simply denying it.

REGULATION STRATEGIES

REAPPRAISE

Change how the situation is interpreted before emotion escalates.

MODIFY THE SITUATION

Change demands, seek support, pause or clarify the interaction.

SUPPRESS EXPRESSION

Hide outward emotion. Sometimes useful briefly; costly as a default.

EI does not make every emotion pleasant; it helps people respond more deliberately.

CLASSROOM APPLICATION

Apply the concepts: an AI-supported customer-service team

After an angry customer call, Nia receives an automated message: “Your emotional tone was below target.” Her supervisor can see the score. Nia feels embarrassed and angry but begins the next call immediately, sounding cheerful. By afternoon she cannot identify one event causing it, but feels tense and disengaged. Her hybrid team rarely speaks outside scheduled meetings.

DIAGNOSE

- Which responses are emotions, and which are moods?
- Where is emotional labour—and is it surface or deep acting?
- Map the case using Affective Events Theory.
- Which EI and regulation strategies could help Nia?
- What should the organization change?

Apply emotion concepts to selection, leadership, decisions, creativity, service, safety and wellbeing.

Emotional intelligence is like a muscle

Its not just being nice!

Developing EI muscles:

- Pay attention to emotion (e.g. mindfulness, mood logging)
- Pay attention to nonverbal cues
- Short circuit negative emotion-> bad mood.
- Be aware of the effects of emotions on behavior/decisions.
- Use your moods.
- Do things that make you and others happy.

(Goleman, 2020)

Good work is designed as a whole system

MOTIVATION

Why invest effort?

Needs • goals • expectations • fairness

JOB DESIGN

What does the work provide?

Meaning • autonomy • learning • feedback

EMOTIONS & MOODS

How is work experienced?

Daily events • emotional labour • regulation

Organizational choices shape all three—through technology, targets, rewards, relationships and everyday treatment.

The future-of-work question

Are we designing work that people can perform, value and sustain?

For tomorrow- sign up to Harvard coursepack